four in 50 overs. Once Gayle is run out by Ashwell Prince and Lara is bowled by Jacques Kallis, the home team subsides and bows out of their own tournament.

In contrast, we are starting to believe. At last, could the World Cup dice finally be starting to fall our way?

Needing one more win to secure a place in the semifinals, we fall short against New Zealand in Grenada, but once again respond well to a must-win situation and overcome England in Barbados, bowling them out for just 154 and then reaching the target with only one wicket down and more than 30 overs to spare.

We look and feel strong as we prepare to play Australia in the semifinal in St Lucia.

Graeme wins the toss and we bat first at the Beauséjour Stadium. Our game plan is to attack, to knock the powerful Australians off their stride and quickly get on top. The plan fails.

Graeme goes first, then Jacques, then me, and then Ashwell and Mark in successive deliveries from McGrath. On a big day, on a day when so many South Africans are sitting in front of their televisions and pinning their hopes on us, we collapsed to 27 for five in the 10th over, and there is no way back. We battle to 149 all out, but the chase is a cruise for the Australians and they coast to victory and yet another World Cup final.

Defeat prompts huge disappointment within the team and back home, and inevitably leads to recriminations.

People suggest the squad is unhappy, divided and run by a clique known as the 'The Big Five': Graeme, Jacques, Mark, Justin Kemp and me. The suggestion is nonsense. I am not aware of any clique, and I have never heard of any group called 'The Big Five'.

Others say our inconsistent performances, alternating between excellent and average, are caused by a drinking culture within the squad. This is more nonsense. We did go out now and then, but no more than any other team in the tournament and no more than was reasonable during